

Grievance and Disciplinary Procedure

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1. Purpose

This document describes two related but distinct processes:

- Grievance procedure — when an employee has a concern or complaint about their work, working conditions, or treatment by a colleague or manager
- Disciplinary procedure — when Zuqah Technologies needs to address an employee's conduct or performance

Both procedures are designed to be fair, consistent and timely. The goal is resolution, not punishment.

2. Grievance procedure

2.1 What is a grievance?

A grievance is a concern, problem or complaint raised by an employee about something Zuqah Technologies has done or failed to do, or about how they have been treated. Examples include:

- Treatment by a manager that feels unfair or disrespectful
- Disagreement with a pay, promotion or performance decision
- Concerns about working conditions
- Bullying or harassment (non-sexual harassment; sexual harassment is covered by the POSH Policy)
- Discrimination (also see the Anti-Discrimination Policy)

2.2 Informal resolution

Before raising a formal grievance, employees are encouraged to resolve the matter informally by speaking to their manager, or to People Operations if the manager is involved. Many concerns can be resolved quickly this way.

2.3 Formal grievance — Step 1: Written complaint

If informal resolution is not possible or appropriate, the employee should submit a written grievance to People Operations at people@zuqahtechnologies.com or by letter. The grievance should describe:

- The nature of the concern
- The people involved
- The dates and circumstances
- What resolution the employee is seeking

Acknowledgement: People Operations will acknowledge the grievance within 3 working days of receipt.

2.4 Formal grievance — Step 2: Investigation meeting

People Operations or a nominated manager will invite the employee to a meeting to discuss the grievance. The employee may bring a colleague or trade union representative as a companion.

The meeting will normally take place within 10 working days of the grievance being acknowledged. Where an investigation is required before the meeting, People Operations will advise of the expected timeline.

2.5 Formal grievance — Step 3: Decision

The investigating manager will provide a written decision within 5 working days of the meeting. The decision will include the findings and any action to be taken.

2.6 Appeal

If the employee is not satisfied with the outcome, they may appeal in writing within 5 working days of receiving the decision. The appeal will be heard by a more senior manager or director who was not involved in the original investigation. The appeal outcome is final.

2.7 Timelines summary

Step	Timeline
Acknowledge written grievance	3 working days
Investigation meeting	Within 10 working days
Written decision	Within 5 working days of meeting
Appeal hearing	Within 10 working days of appeal
Appeal decision	Within 5 working days of appeal hearing

3. Disciplinary procedure

The disciplinary procedure applies where Zuqah Technologies has concerns about an employee's conduct or performance.

3.1 Scope

This procedure applies to all employees, including those on probation. It does not apply to contractors. Separate performance improvement plans may apply to performance concerns outside the formal disciplinary process.

3.2 Informal action

For minor conduct or performance issues, a manager may address the matter informally with a conversation or coaching. This will not be recorded on the employee's HR file.

3.3 Investigation

Before any formal disciplinary action is taken, Zuqah Technologies will carry out a reasonable investigation. The manager will gather relevant information, which may include speaking to witnesses and reviewing records.

During investigation of a serious allegation, the employee may be suspended on full pay while the investigation is completed. Suspension is a neutral act and does not prejudice the outcome.

3.4 Disciplinary hearing — Step 1: Notice

The employee will receive written notice of the disciplinary hearing at least 3 working days in advance. The notice will include:

- The specific concerns or allegations
- The evidence gathered
- The potential consequences
- The employee's right to bring a companion

3.5 Disciplinary hearing — Step 2: The hearing

The hearing gives the employee a full opportunity to respond to the concerns raised and to present their version of events. They may call witnesses.

3.6 Disciplinary outcome

Following the hearing, the manager will decide on one of the following outcomes, communicated in writing:

Outcome	When used
No further action	Concern not substantiated
Verbal warning	Minor first offence
Written warning	Repeated or more serious offence; recorded for 6 months
Final written warning	Serious or repeated; recorded for 12 months
Dismissal with notice	Serious misconduct or continued issues after final warning
Summary dismissal	Gross misconduct (immediate, without notice)

3.7 Gross misconduct

The following are examples of gross misconduct for which immediate dismissal may result:

- Theft or fraud
- Physical violence or threats of violence
- Sexual harassment or serious bullying

- Deliberate damage to company property
- Serious breach of data protection obligations
- Falsification of records, including expense claims
- Being under the influence of alcohol or illegal substances at work
- Bringing the company into serious disrepute

This list is not exhaustive.

3.8 Appeal

The employee may appeal any disciplinary decision within 5 working days of receiving the written outcome. Appeals are heard by a director or senior manager not previously involved. The appeal decision is final.

3.9 Timelines summary

Step	Timeline
Notice of disciplinary hearing	At least 3 working days in advance
Written outcome	Within 5 working days of hearing
Appeal lodged	Within 5 working days of outcome
Appeal hearing	Within 10 working days of appeal

4. Right to a companion

In all formal grievance and disciplinary hearings, the employee has the right to be accompanied by a colleague currently employed by Zuqah Technologies. This companion may address the hearing, sum up the employee's case and confer with the employee during the hearing, but may not answer questions on the employee's behalf.

5. Confidentiality

All grievance and disciplinary proceedings are confidential. Parties to the process, including witnesses, must not discuss the matter outside the process. Breach of confidentiality may itself lead to disciplinary action.

6. No detriment

Raising a genuine grievance or cooperating in a disciplinary investigation will not result in any detriment. Managers who treat an employee unfavourably for exercising their rights under this policy will face disciplinary action.

Sample content for demonstration purposes. Zuqah Technologies is a fictional company and this document describes no real organisation's policy.